

The Seattle Times



BACKGROUND INFORMATION

The Seattle Times, a trusted local news outlet with a legacy spanning over 130 years, has been family-owned since 1896 and serves as the primary source of news for the Seattle area and surrounding communities. Renowned for its investigative journalism and community-focused reporting, the brand consistently innovates by delivering uniquely local stories through engaging and accessible digital and print experiences. From breaking news updates to curated newsletters, The Seattle Times reflects its longstanding commitment to public service, informing and inspiring the Pacific Northwest through its content, platforms, and community programs.

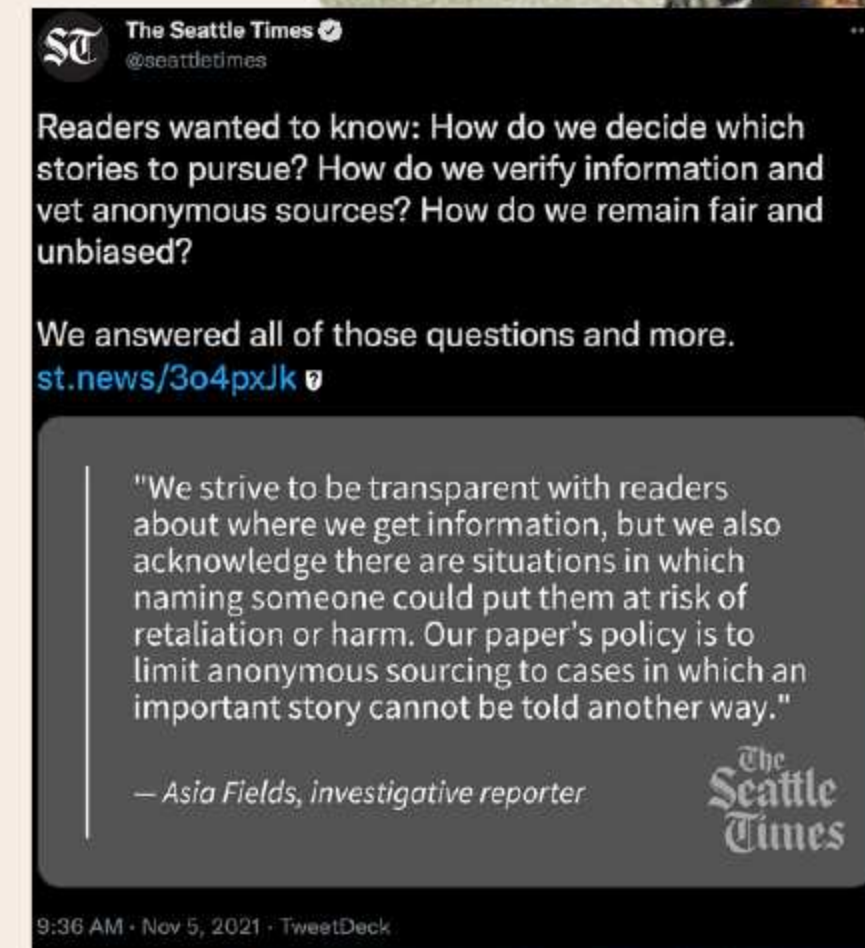


REASON FOR THE PROJECT

- Declining print media & shift to digital platforms
- Paywall Barriers
- Targeting younger audiences
- Competition with other popular news brand

OBJECTIVES

- Increase brand awareness by 30% and digital subscriptions by 20% around the Seattle area within six months by highlighting The Seattle Times' trusted, community-focused journalism to engage readers aged 25-45.



RESEARCH METHODS

01. Individual Interviews

02. Social Media Analysis
(Meltwater)

03. Overall News
Brands Analysis
(MRI Data)

01. Local Loyalty & Regional Authority

02. Content Preferences & Emotional Impact

03. Paywall and Accessibility Challenges

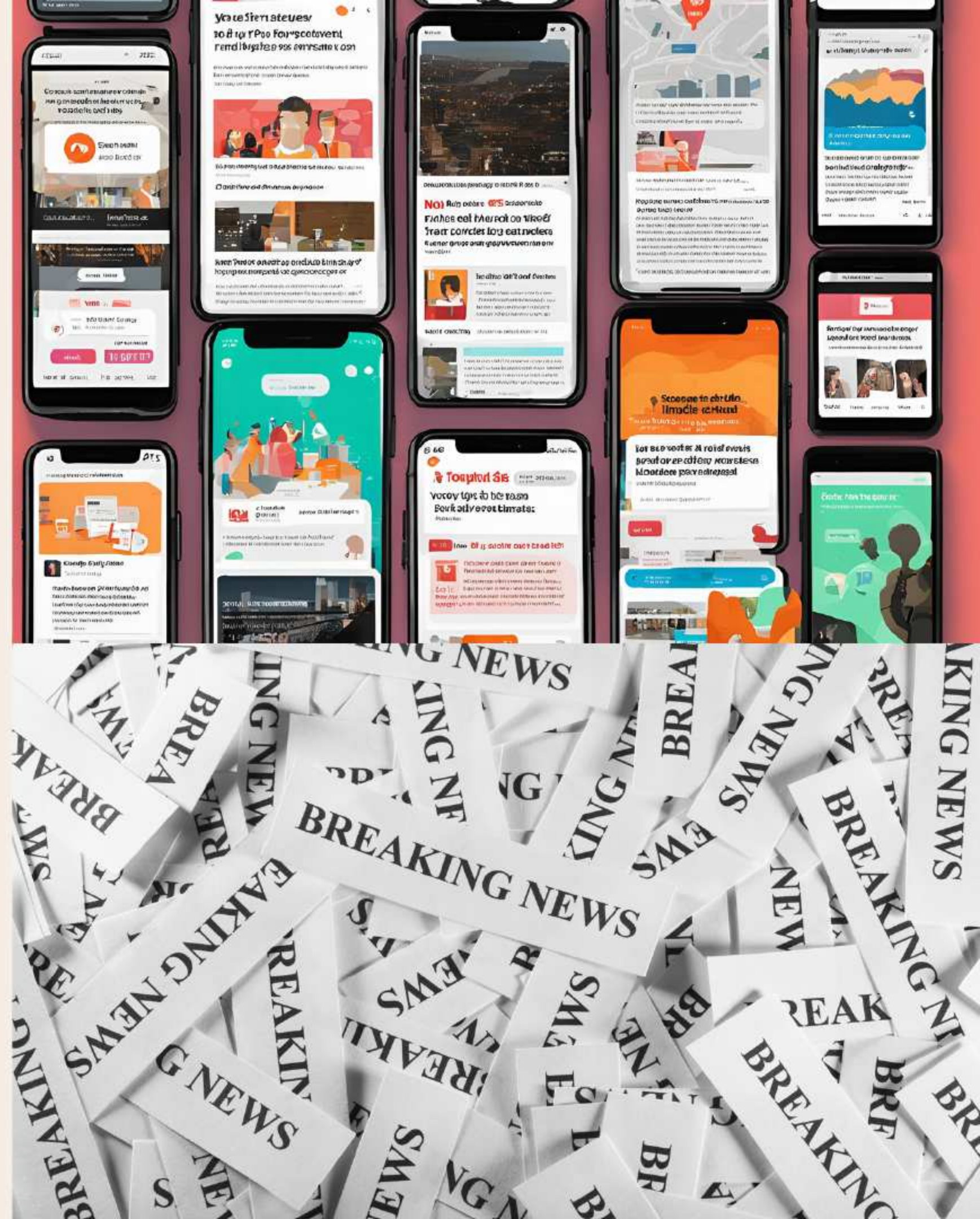
RESEARCH FINDING

BACKGROUND CONTEXT

TRENDS AFFECTING THE INDUSTRIES

- Decline of Paper Media
- Rise of Digital Subscription
- Dominance of Social Media and Aggregators
- Audience Shifts
- Trust and Credibility Challenges
- Opportunities in Digital Innovation

(Bhuller et al., 2023)
(Atske, 2024)
(Haile, 2020)
(Pew Research Center, 2023)
(MRI 2, 2024)



BRAND ANALYSIS

01

Founded in 1896 with 11 Pulitzer Prizes, The Seattle Times is a trusted local news outlet and the most-visited digital news source in Washington state.

02

- Mission
- Vision
- Key Values

03

- A regional publication offering both print and digital editions
- Strong emphasis on local issues

04

- Independence through local ownership and deep community engagement
- Financial pressures from declining print circulation

COMPETITON



- Local Competitor: Seattle Post-Intelligencer
- National Competitors: The New York Times & CNN
- Global Competitor: BBC
- Digital Aggregators and Social Media



(Bhuller et al., 2023)

(Lipka, 2023)

(Pew Research Center, 2023)

(MRI 2, 2024)

TARGET AUDIENCE PROFILE

Interview Quote

"In Seattle, most people I know use The Seattle Times; it's what everyone knows here,"

PERSONA

Age: 29
Gender: Female
Occupation:
Graduate Student
Family: Married
Favorite Social
Media: Facebook
Location: Seattle



Claire is a middle class worker and just began her graduate program. She enjoys reading the news in her spare time. She has disposable income and likes to spend money on content that informs her about local news.

Behavior

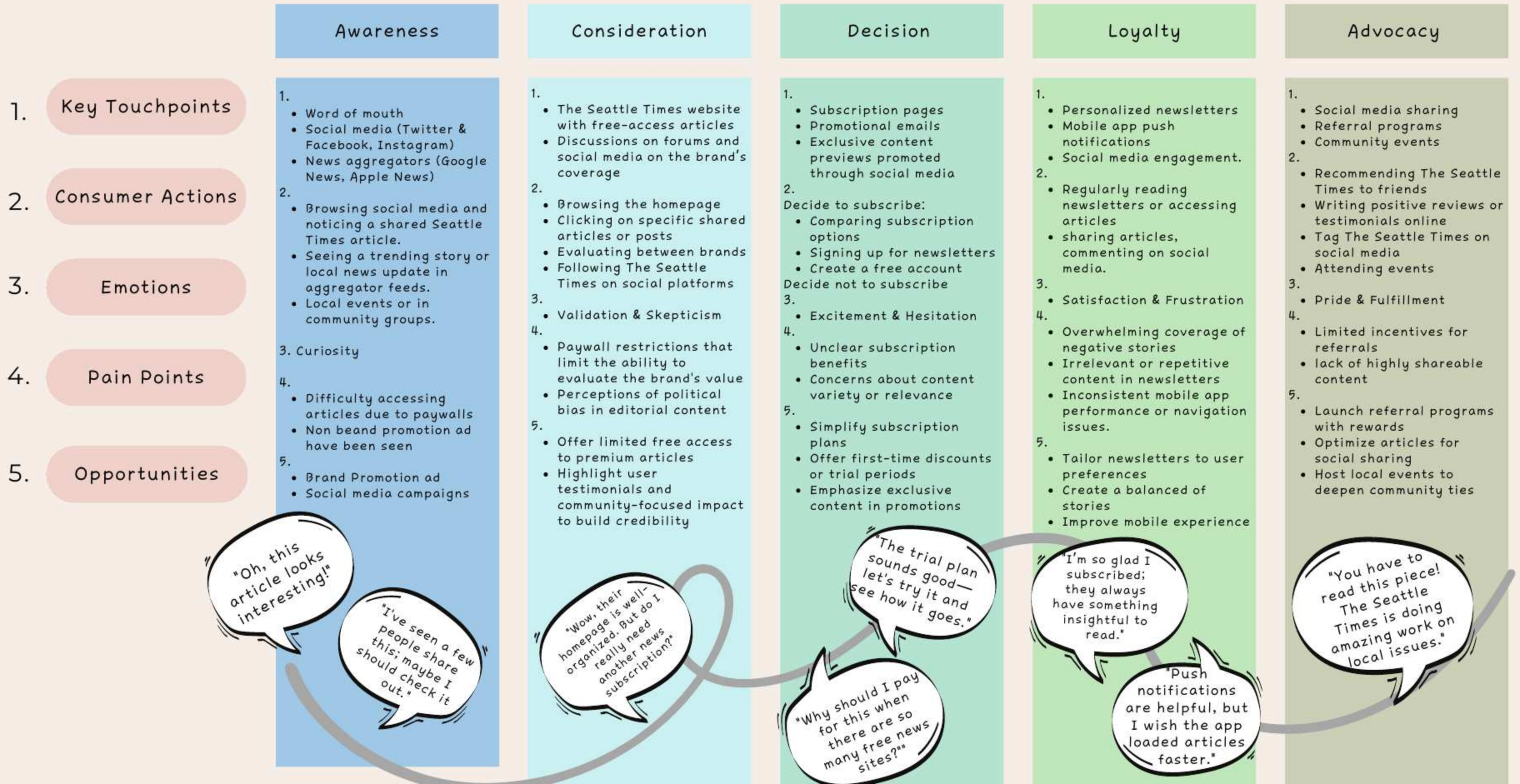
- Likes to follow trends according to what her peers are recommending.
- Reading local news on digital platform every morning
- Spends over two hours daily on social media platforms like Facebook and Instagram

Psych:

- Chooses news that aligns with her beliefs, which reinforces her existing convictions
- Concerning about local events

**" I LIKE STAYING ON TOP OF
WHAT IS GOING ON AROUND
ME. I VALUE LOCAL NEWS
AND MAKES ME FEEL
CONNECTED TO MY
COMMUNITY EVEN MORE."**

CONSUMER JOURNEY MAP



KEY INSIGHTS



Young audiences crave authentic, objective news that connects to their daily lives and interests. Some find that much of the content feels irrelevant to their interests, making it harder to connect with traditional news outlets. Local residents tend to rely on free resources to access news and are often deterred by paywalls, choosing to avoid them rather than pay for subscription-based content. They want content that can be tailored to their interests, with easy access across different devices, allowing them to engage with the news in a way that fits their lifestyle.



RECOMMENDATIONS

1. Expand Digital Accessibility
2. Enhance Social Media Presence
3. Prioritize Local and Relevant Content
4. Address Paywall Challenges
5. Increase Brand Awareness
6. Build Trust and Credibility



Brand: The Seattle Times

Brand Overview

Founded in 1891 and owned by the Blethen family since 1896, The Seattle Times is a trusted local news outlet renowned for its investigative journalism and community-focused reporting. Its readership includes highly educated Seattle-area residents, college students, and influential professionals, with a significant portion of its audience being older and high-income individuals. While it maintains strong loyalty among its core audience, The Seattle Times faces challenges in attracting younger, digitally savvy readers and competing with national news platforms in an increasingly digital news environment.

Target Audience

- Age Distribution: 25–45 years old
- Income Level: Middle to high-income individuals.
- Education Level: The audience is highly educated.
- Gender Ratio: Balanced
- Region: Primarily residents of the Greater Seattle area and surrounding states
- Socially conscious, community-driven, and interested in credible, objective news.
- Willing to pay for news that align with their interests and support personal growth and awareness.
- Daily social media and digital platform users who prefer mobile-friendly news
- Actively share and discuss news that resonates with their interests and values.

Objective

- Increase brand awareness by 30% and digital subscriptions by 20% around the Seattle area within six months by highlighting The Seattle Times' trusted, community-focused journalism to engage readers aged 25–45.
- GET**
- Digital-first, socially conscious readers aged 25–45 in Seattle and surrounding areas.
- TO**
- Choose The Seattle Times as their primary news source
- BY**
- Highlighting its credibility, community impact, and accessibility through modern digital storytelling and targeted campaigns.

Challenge

- Overcoming perceptions of limited accessibility due to paywalls and addressing the lack of awareness among younger audiences (25–45 age group) and readers around the Seattle area due to no brand promotion advertisements.
- Consumers have expressed concerns about The Seattle Times' political coverage, with some feeling it favors specific candidates or perspectives, leading to mistrust and scrutiny.

Opportunity

- Launch brand promotion campaigns to increase awareness and showcase its trusted local journalism.
- By ensuring that the news recommendations align closely with readers' interests, the platform can avoid content overload and prevent fatigue, ultimately fostering greater engagement and increasing subscription retention.
- Address paywall frustrations by introducing a freemium model with limited free access to premium content.
- Strengthen its digital presence through targeted social media campaigns and user-friendly mobile experiences.

Insight

Young audiences crave authentic, objective news that connects to their daily lives and interests. Some find that much of the content feels irrelevant to their interests, making it harder to connect with traditional news outlets. Local residents tend to rely on free resources to access news and are often deterred by paywalls, choosing to avoid them rather than pay for subscription-based content. They want content that can be tailored to their interests, with easy access across different devices, allowing them to engage with the news in a way that fits their lifestyle.

Advantage

Reading local news provides young readers with immediate and practical value, helping them to develop a deeper connection to their surroundings. By focusing on events, opportunities and resources in the community, local news makes information relevant and actionable. Many young people may feel disconnected from traditional news, but local news can bridge that gap and give them a sense of control and belonging to their surroundings. By focusing on timely, authentic content with cultural and social context, local news not only helps young people understand what' s going on in their communities, but also inspires them to participate in more meaningful ways.

Strategy

- Position The Seattle Times as a digital-first news leader by combining investigative depth with modern, mobile-friendly content that appeals to socially conscious, digitally savvy readers.
- Emphasize its role in connecting communities while addressing accessibility concerns through a freemium model.

Key Message

The Seattle Times connects you to the stories that shape our community, inspire change, and bring us closer together.

Reasons to Believe (RTB's)

- Award-winning investigative journalism
- Hyper-local reporting on Seattle and the Pacific Northwest that national outlets cannot replicate
- Engaging coverage of topics like social justice, local culture, and sports
- Mobile-friendly platforms for easy access to news anytime, anywhere
- Freemium content model that offers value for free and premium subscribers

Desired Response

Consumers should view The Seattle Times as a trusted and reliable source of news that keeps them connected to their community and informed about important issues. They should feel confident in the brand' s commitment to impactful journalism and inspired by its focus on delivering meaningful, local, and investigative stories. This connection should lead them to subscribe to The Seattle Times and actively engage with its content across social media and digital platforms.

Tone of Voice

Trustworthy, Community-Oriented, Modern & Approachable

Deliverables

- Digital Campaigns (Social Media, etc.)
- Website Enhancement
- Subscription Promotion
- OOH

Creative Mandatories

- Use The Seattle Times' logo and tagline in all materials.
- Community-focused stories and highlight investigative journalism.
- Ensure all content is mobile-friendly and visually engaging.

CREATIVE BRIEF

CHALLENGE

Overcome paywall barriers and lack of awareness among younger audiences while addressing concerns about perceived political bias



OPPORTUNITIES



Utilize targeted campaigns, brand-related advertising, freemium models and stronger digital presence to drive awareness and engagement

INSIGHT

Younger readers prioritize accessible, relevant, and objective news that fits their interests and lifestyles.



ADVANTAGES

Local news connects readers to their communities and provides viable and meaningful content that is often lacking in national media.



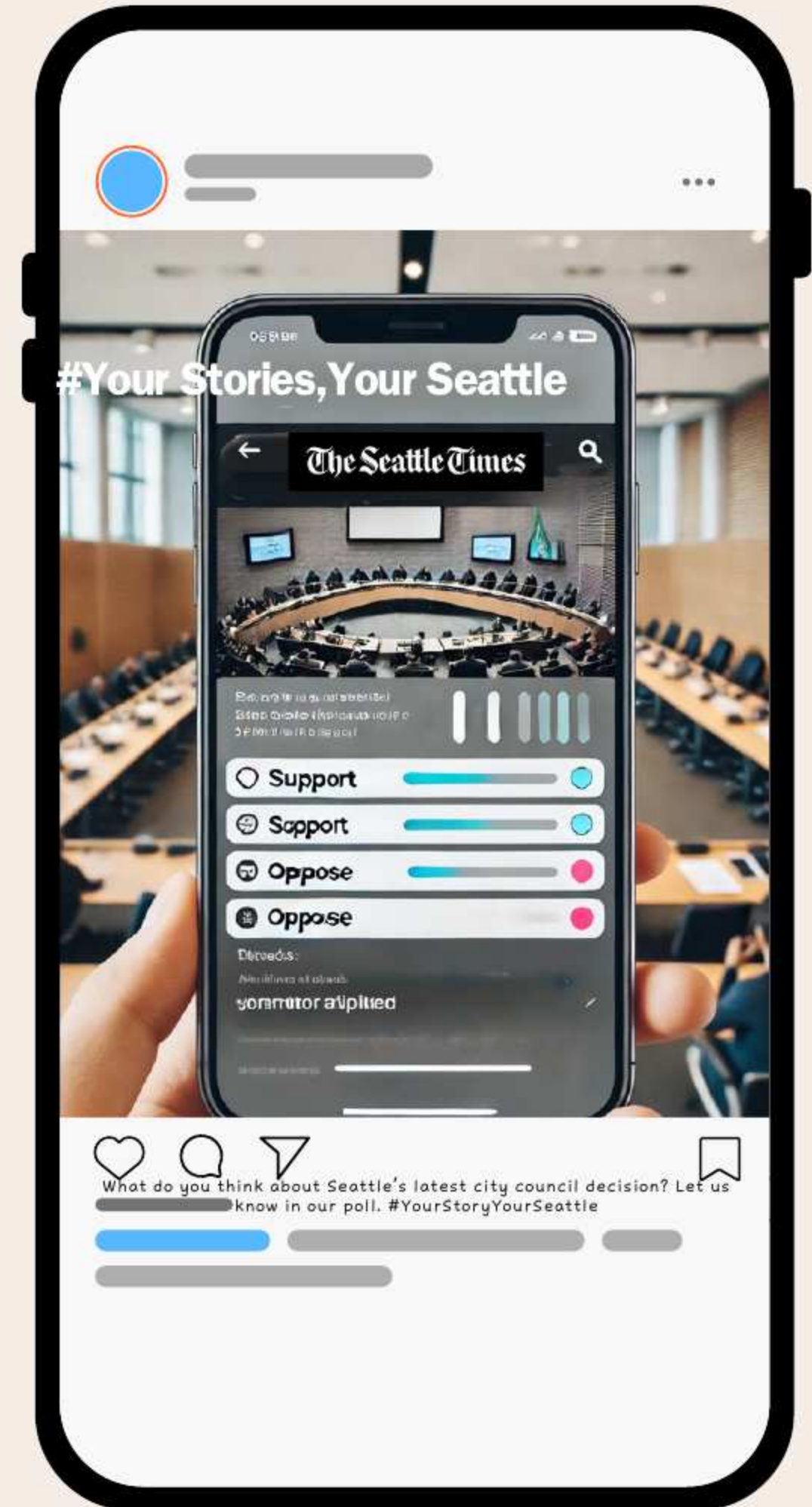
STRATEGY

Position The Seattle Times as a digital-first leader offering trusted, community-driven journalism through engaging and accessible platforms.

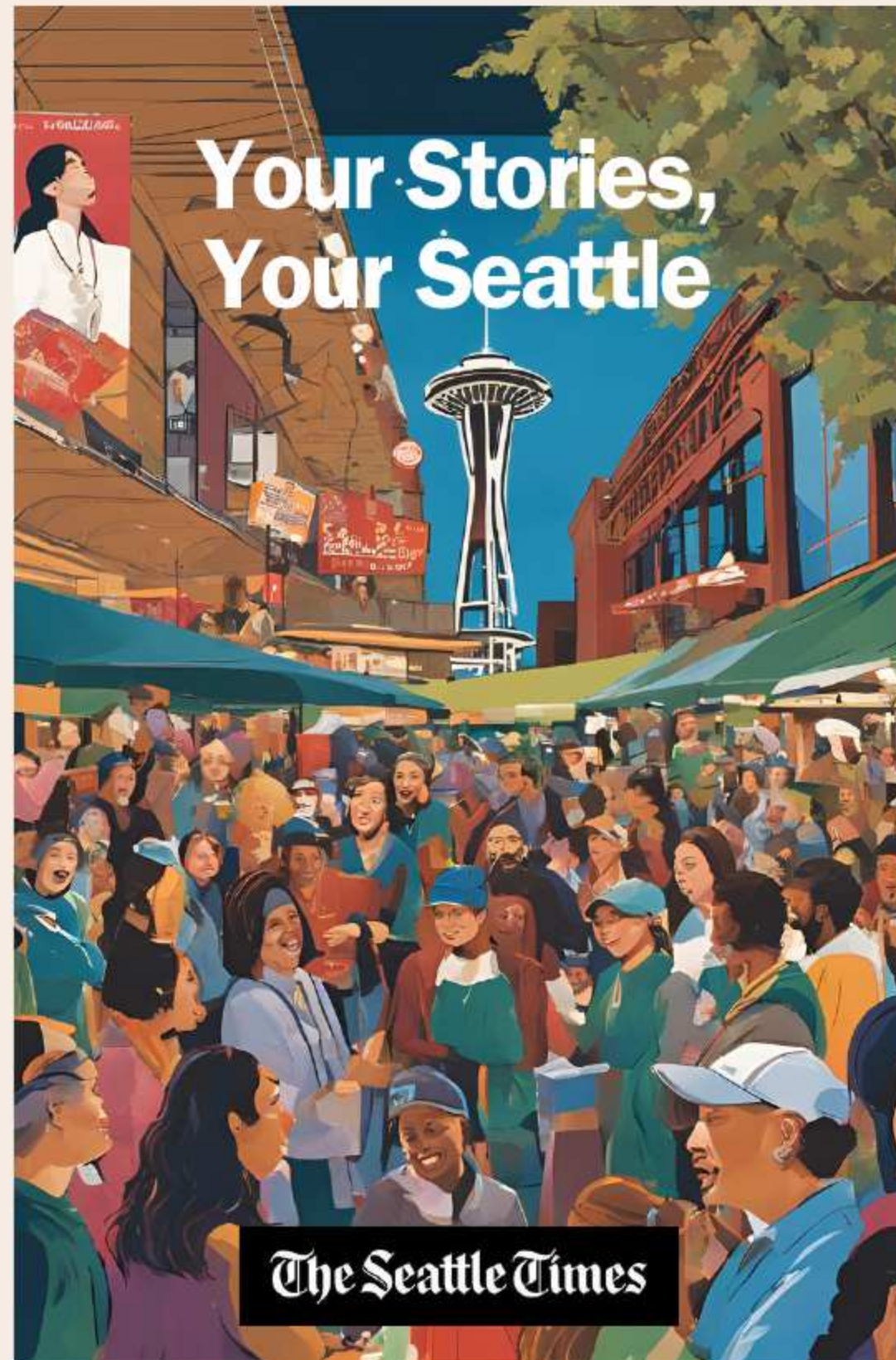
SOCIAL AD EXAMPLE

Your Stories, Your Seattle

- Use Instagram Stories and Twitter/X to provide live updates on major breaking news, such as local elections or sports events.
- Include real time polls and Q&A sessions for followers to engage
- Example post: "What do you think about Seattle's latest city council decision? Let us know in our poll. #YourStoryYourSeattle"



VISUAL AD EXAMPLE



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Meltwater

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A. DETAILS OF RESEARCH PARTICIPANTS

APPENDIX								
NAME	AGE	GENDER	OCCUPATI ON	REGION	METHOD	DATE	WHERE	DURATION (MIN)
JJ	40-ish	M	Professor	Boston	In Person	Oct. 24	Classroom	11:38
CP	50-ish	M	Professor	Boston	In Person	Oct. 30	Classroom	14:03
Shirlin	21	F	Graduate student	Seattle- Bostin	In Person	Oct. 26	At home	3:53
Claire	25	F	Graduate student	Atlanta & Taiwan- Boston	In Person	Oct. 31	Studyroom	11:13
Alex	24	M	Graduate student	Seattle- Boston	In Person	Oct. 27	At home	3:45
Du	23	M	Graduate student	China - Boston	In Person	Oct. 26	Studyroom	4:10
Chen	24	M	Graduate student	China- Connecticu t	In Person	Oct. 26	Studyroom	4:30

APPENDIX

B. INTERVIEW GUIDE

1. Can you describe your overall media consumption habits?
 - What types of media do you engage with regularly? (TV, social media, podcasts, print, etc.)
 - The frequency of media platform? How often do you read news?
 - Is it a way to relax, stay informed, or connect with others?
2. What motivates you to consume media?
 - Is it for information, entertainment, social engagement, or something else?
3. What media platforms do you use for news?
4. What makes a news brand reliable to you?
5. How do you know you are reading reliable news? And why?
6. What type of sources do you use to identify a news as “real” news?
7. Do you know which news brands your friends use?
8. What news do your family members use?
9. Do you or your family subscribe to any news?
10. When you see a paywall, do you continue to read or rather choose free media?
11. Do you take the initiative to share news with people around you?
12. What article that you have read stood out to you the most?
13. What types of news content do you engage with most?
 - Local news, national news, sports, culture, opinion pieces, etc.

APPENDIX

C. EXTRA MATERIALS

DATE FOR TOP MENTION/ MENTION TRENDS



AI CLUSTERS FOR POPULAR TRENDS

AI-Powered Clusters

Clusters	Mentions
1 Democrat Adam Frisch has widened his campaign cash advantage over Republican U.S. Rep. Lauren Boebert in Colorado's 3rd District, outpacing her by a factor of nearly four from July through September.	176
2 Former medical director sues Seattle Children's hospital alleging racial discrimination	50
3 Jerry Diputo tells Mariners fans what they don't want to hear	46
4 Rant: Seattle cop reports own conversation, fears of out-of-context smears	41
5 A congressional investigation has revealed major pharmacies routinely reveal customers' medical records to police and the government without a warrant, according to the Washington Post.	41
6 Rosenthal: Rangers earn celebration with playoff clinch, but MLB's final day has a lot at stake	21
7 The verdict in the Manny Ellis wrongful death trial led to protests in Tacoma, where police officers were charged in the death of George Floyd.	20

TOP ENGAGED TOPICS

Top Topics

Topics	Mentions	Trend
1 News	19.7k	→ 0%
2 Law and government	5.25k	→ 0%
3 Sensitive subjects	4.79k	→ 0%
4 People and society	3.83k	→ 0%
5 Sports	2.34k	→ 0%
6 Business and industrial	1.7k	→ 0%
7 Arts and entertainment	1.65k	→ 0%

TOP MENTION CONTENT COMMENT/ TWEET

Texas Sports TV @TexasSportsTV
X | Sep 28, 2023 · 10:18 PM

[QT] . I'm proud homophobic at this point. ; Video replays appear to show Hector Neris using a homophobic slur in Spanish when he approached Julio Rodriguez. Mariners' Eugenio Suarez, in the on deck circle at the time, confirmed to The **Seattle Times** that that's what Neris said.

Seattle Times

238 Reach Negative

TWEET 1

@wesslemania
X | Sep 28, 2023 ·

[QT] statement seen by over a million people? ; Video replays appear to show Hector Neris using a homophobic slur in Spanish when he approached Julio Rodriguez. Mariners' Eugenio Suarez, in the on deck circle at the time, confirmed to The **Seattle Times** that that's what Neris said.

Seattle Times

17 Reach Negative

TWEET 2

EMOTIONS TOWARD THE BRAND BASED ON TOPICS

Top Keyword Sentiment



POSITIVE COMMENTS ON TWEET

Steve Zimmerman @badgerzip2002
X | US | Dec 31, 2023 · 10:47 PM

[RT] @richboudet: Dawgs unleashed / Monday's **Seattle Times** features our 10-page Huskies playoff preview with a fantastic cover illustration by @sportingpress1 @SeaTimesSports <https://t.co/TgQgWW6z6k>

Seattle Times

414 Reach 12 Duplicates Positive

Chari @chamaker23
X | US | Dec 31, 2023 · 9:59 PM

[QT] @richboudet: I need this paper <https://t.co/XjEXaynu9l> ; Dawgs unleashed / Monday's **Seattle Times** features our 10-page Huskies playoff preview with a fantastic cover illustration by @sportingpress1 @SeaTimesSports <https://t.co/TgQgWW6z6k>

Seattle Times

594 Reach 4 Engagement Neutral

A decorative border made of watercolor brushstrokes in shades of green, orange, and blue, framing the central text.

THANK YOU
VERY MUCH!